

Virna Vidal-Menezes

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FIELDS OF INTEREST

Development Economics, Labor Economics, and Economics of Education.

EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame, South Bend, Indiana 2021 — 2027 (exp.)
PhD in Economics

Federal University of Ceara, Fortaleza, CE, Brazil 2018 — 2020
MA in Economics

Federal University of Ceara, Fortaleza, CE, Brazil 2013 — 2017
BA in Economics Honors: Magna Cum Laude

JOB MARKET PAPER

“Looking ahead? The Role of Future Educational Opportunities on Pre-college Educational Attainment”

Abstract: How do future schooling opportunities shape early educational decisions? In this paper, I exploit a large expansion in the supply of free higher education institutions (HEIs) in Brazil to analyze the role of tertiary education opportunities in increasing returns to basic schooling in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs). To understand how higher education expansion can increase demand for pre-tertiary schooling, I develop a simple framework that highlights the channels of impact and the necessary conditions for downstream effects to occur. Empirically, I employ a novel dataset on HEI roll-out combined with rich administrative data, and estimate the effect of receiving an HEI on local public students' pre-college outcomes using a staggered difference-in-differences design. Students in treated municipalities are 2% more likely to graduate from high school and 20% more likely to take a college-entry exam. These effects are driven solely by increased access to higher education rather than by local labor market changes, with local students' enrollment in federal HEIs increasing by 70% following the policy. Consistent with the framework, empirical evidence supports the prediction that the college premium is key to generating downstream effects: changes in high school graduation are positive only in municipalities with a high pre-policy college premium, and largest where the college premium is high and the secondary premium is low. Expanding access to higher education in contexts where college returns are high can therefore be a powerful tool for improving early educational attainment, especially in low- and middle-income settings where stand-alone returns to high school are not enough to keep students in school.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

University of Notre Dame South Bend, Indiana
Research Assistant to Professor Taryn Dinkelman August 2022 – May 2026

Inter-American Development Bank Washington, D.C.
Consultant Intern at the Research Department June 2024 – August 2024

University of Virginia and University of Notre Dame Kampala, Uganda
Survey Field Coordinator May 2023 – July 2023

Research Institute for Technology and Innovation - IPTI Aracaju, SE, Brazil
Impact Evaluation Researcher February 2021 – July 2021

Federal University of Ceara Fortaleza, CE, Brazil
Research Assistant to Professor Guilherme Diniz Irffi August 2019 – July 2021

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

“Schooling, Jobs, Political Attitudes and Actions: Evidence from Free Primary Education Policies in Africa” with Taryn Dinkelman

“Determinants of Free Primary Education Laws and Policies in Africa: A new dataset” with Taryn Dinkelman and Amadou Jawo

“The Comprehensive Impacts of a National Inclusion Policy for Students with Disabilities” with Angelo dos Santos and Ramon Lima Ribeiro

“How Significant is the Impact of a Negative Grade Shock?” with Zhongheng Qiao and Ge Sun

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Principles of Microeconomics. Course Evaluation: 5/5. June 2026 - July 2026

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Introduction to Linear Regression. Course Evaluation: 5/5. October 2024 - December 2024

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Development Data Stata Bootcamp. May 2024

Getulio Vargas Foundation (FGV), School of Public Policy and Government Brasilia, DF, Brazil
Teaching Assistant, Graduate Causal Inference for Public Policy. August 2020 - December 2020

GRANTS, HONORS AND AFFILIATIONS

National Academy of Education (NAEd) and Spencer Foundation Washington, D.C.
NAEd/Spencer Dissertation Fellowship September 2026 - Present

Kellogg Institute for International Studies South Bend, Indiana
Kellogg Graduate Research Grant January 2026

Arnold Ventures San Francisco, California
Grant to attend the “Differences-in-Differences Causal Inference Workshop”, taught by Prof. Wooldridge November 2024

Building Inclusive Growth (BIG) Lab South Bend, Indiana
BIG Lab Doctoral Student Affiliate May 2023 – Present

Kellogg Institute for International Studies South Bend, Indiana
Kellogg Doctoral Student Affiliate February 2023 – Present

Notre Dame Program for Interdisciplinary Educational Research (PIER) South Bend, Indiana
Notre Dame Burns Fellow August 2021 – Present

Itau Social Sao Paulo, SP, Brazil
Grant to attend the course “Advanced Course in Public Policy and Social Projects Evaluation” January 2020 – March 2020

SERVICE AND PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

Referee: Journal of Human Resources

Office of Grants and Fellowships, University of Notre Dame
Speaker on Grant and Fellowship Winners Panel

South Bend, Indiana
August 2026

Department of Economics, University of Notre Dame
Graduate Student Committee Co-chair

South Bend, Indiana
August 2023 – May 2024

Getulio Vargas Foundation (FGV) and Itau Social
Advanced Summer Course in Public Policy and Social Projects Evaluation

Sao Paulo, SP, Brazil
January 2020 – March 2020

PRESENTATIONS

2026 Midwest International Economic Development Conference (MWIEDC), MidSouth Education Policy Workshop (scheduled), Midwest Economics of Education (scheduled)

2025 Association for Public Policy and Analysis (APPAM) Fall Conference

2024 Southern Economic Association (SEA) 94th Annual Meeting

SKILLS AND PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- **Technical Skills:** Stata, Matlab, R, SurveyCTO, LaTeX.
- **Language Skills:** Portuguese (native), English (fluent), French (advanced), and Spanish (advanced).
- **Professional Memberships:** Association for Public Policy and Analysis (APPAM), American Economic Association (AEA), Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP), American Educational Research Association (AERA), Society for Research on Educational Effectiveness (SREE).

Last updated: September 3, 2026